Alabama Learning Hour

Ava's animals, Two types of Possession

October 22, 2026

1 *Ava innaasi iyyi ostaakaha*

Ava innaasi iyyi ostaakaha

Ava's animals - Alabama Text

naasi iyyi ostaaka ava imiisafa lahwahchi.
iisahayon kati lochan, ifa hatkak iisahchi.
achan akaakak tałłaapin, aayampo kolokbifan łałok nampobi.
ya łałok laanahchi, ahki łałok okchakkohchi.
chassi imiisafan chichobon hiichali?
oh, waakoolo.
Avak hachonchoban bannati, maamin taatak waakan choopati.
ittofan sawak wiikahchi.
sawak Avan imbiniilihchi.
stanooko!

Ava's animals - English translation

There are a lot of animals at Ava's home.
In the house, a black cat and a white dog live.
Outside, there are five chickens, and in the bowl, there are many fish.
This fish is yellow, that fish is green.
Do I see a horse in the barn?
No, it is a cow.
Ava wanted an aligator, but dad bought a cow.
In a tree, the raccoon lives.
The raccoon visits Ava.
the end!

2 Vocabulary

Nouns

naasi iyyi ostaaka	animal
iisa	house
kati	cat
ifa	dog
akaaka	chicken
aayampo	dish
kolokbi	deep hole
aayampo kolokbi	bowl
łałło	fish
chassi imiisa	barn
chassi	corn
chichoba	horse
waaka	cow
hachonchoba	alligator
hachi	tail
choba	big
taata	dad
itto	tree
sawa	raccoon

Verbs

lahwa	to be many, a lot
nampo	to be many
iisa	to live at a place
hiicha	to see
banna	to want
choopa	to buy
wiika	to stay, be, live
imbiniili	to visit
anooka	to be gone, finished up

Adjectives

locha	black
hatka	white
laana	yellow
okchakko	green

Other

acha	outside
taɬɬaapi	five
ya	this
ahki	that
maamin	but, however
stanooko	the end

3 Possession

- When we talk about nouns, we may also want to talk about *possession*
  - e.g. *my cat*, *your cat*
- To talk about *possession*, nouns can "combine" with other nouns to describe the individual who owns, possesses it—the individual that the noun belongs to.

(1) **Possessors**
are arguments of nouns that describe individuals who are related to the noun by the possession/ownership/belonging relationship.

(2) **Possessee**
the thing or individual being had, owned, possessed is called **Possessee**.

(3) **my** **friend**
POSSESSOR POSSESSEE

- In Alabama, nouns differ in how their possessors are expressed! Consider 'my friend' vs. 'my name':

(4) **am** + **okla**
my + friend
POSSESSOR

(5) **cha** + **holchifa**
my + name
POSSESSSOR

- Most nouns take *am*-Possessors (II), but some nouns, which often express kinship terms and body parts, take *cha*-Possessors (I)—they need to be remembered. Here are some of them:

Some nouns that take *cha*-Possessors (I)

- **ifoni** 'sister (of a man)'
- **halki** 'wife'
- **ochoosi** 'son, child'
- **ostayki** 'daughter'
- **hachi** 'tail'
- **hissi** 'hair'
- **iyyi** 'foot'
- **sakba** 'arm'

- If a noun is one of this special list (nouns with *cha*-Possessors, I), we will say "my noun" by adding prefix *cha-* to the noun, and we will say "your noun" by adding the prefix *chi-*. Note that *chi-* implies that you are addressing only one person.

(6) [**cha** + **Noun**]
my

(7) [**chi** + **Noun**]
your

- To say that this type of noun belongs to some third person (Ava, the child, dad), we just put two nouns together:

(8) [POSSESSOR + **Noun**]

(9) [Ava + **hissi**]
Ava's **hair**

Let's practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

Note: if the word starts with [i] or [o], they will disappear; e.g. *ifoni* → *cha-foni*

ifoni 'sister (of a man)'

(10) a. my sister
b. your sister
c. Jacob's sister

halki 'wife'

(11) a. my wife
b. your wife
c. Jackson's wife

ochoosi 'son'

(12) a. my son
b. your son
c. Romi's son

ostayki 'daughter'

(13) a. my daughter
b. your daughter
c. Deb's daughter

hachi 'tail'

(14) a. my tail
b. your tail
c. aligator's (*hachonchoba*) tail

hissi 'hair'

(15) a. my hair
b. your hair
c. Nicla's hair

iyyi 'foot'

(16) a. my foot
b. your foot
c. baby's (*aatosi*) foot

sakba 'arm'

(17) a. my arm
b. your arm
c. dad's (*taata*) arm

- Now let's try putting these nouns into a sentence.

(18) [**my/your-noun**]-**k** [**my/your-noun**]-**n** hiicha-ti
-SUBJECT -OBJECT see-PAST

(19) **cha-foni-k** **chi-hachi-n** hiicha-ti
my-sister-SUBJECT your-tail-OBJECT see-PAST
'My sister saw your tail.'

Let's practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

(20) a. My sister saw your tail.
b. Your sister saw my tail.

(21) a. Your wife saw my hair.
b. My wife saw your hair.

(22) a. My son saw your foot.
b. Your son saw my foot.

(23) a. Your daughter saw my arm.
b. My daughter saw your arm.

- **ifoni** 'sister (of a man)'
- **halki** 'wife'
- **ochoosi** 'son, child'
- **ostayki** 'daughter'
- **hachi** 'tail'
- **hissi** 'hair'
- **iyyi** 'foot'
- **sakba** 'arm'

- If a noun is *not* on the special list, it takes an *am*-Possessor (type 2).
- We will say "my noun" by adding prefix *am-* to the noun, and we will say "your noun" by adding the prefix *chim-*. Note that *chim-* implies that you are addressing only one person.

(24) [**am** + **Noun**]
my

(25) [**chim** + **Noun**]
your

- To say that this type of noun belongs to some third person (Ava, the child, dad), we put two nouns together:

(26) [POSSESSOR + **im-Noun**]
his/her

(27) [Ava + **im-hissi**]
Ava **'s-hair**

- Notice that all these little pieces we add end in [m]: *am-, chim-, im-*. When [m] is followed by a vowel ([i], [a], [o]), it is easy to pronounce.
- But when [m] is followed by a consonant—in particular, sounds like [t], [ch], [n], or [k], pronouncing two sounds in a row is a bit difficult. To help the speakers, Alabama changes [m] → [n] in such cases. For example:

(28)
a. my basket: am + kolbi → a**n**-kolbi
b. my cornbread: am + chakaawa → a**n**-chakaawa
c. my man: am + naani → a**n**-naani
d. my flour: am + tilko → a**n**-tilko

Let's practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

okla 'friend'

(29)
a. my friend
b. your friend
c. Jacob's friend

taata 'dad'

(30)
a. my dad
b. your dad
c. Jackson's dad

iisa 'house'

(31)
a. my house
b. your house
c. Romi's house

kati 'cat'

(32)
a. my cat
b. your cat
c. Deb's cat

ifa 'dog'

(33)
a. my dog
b. your dog
c. baby's (*aatosi*) dog

chassi 'corn'

(34)
a. my corn
b. your corn
c. Nicla's corn

akaaka 'chicken'

(35)
a. my chicken
b. your chicken
c. dad's (*taata*) chicken

naaɬiika 'language'

(36)
a. my language
b. your language
c. Ava's language

- Now let's try putting these nouns into a sentence.

(37) [**my/your-noun**]-**k** [**my/your-noun**]-**n** hiicha-ti
-SUBJECT -OBJECT see-PAST

(38) **am-okla-k** **chim-ifa-n** hiicha-ti
my-sister-SUBJECT your-tail-OBJECT see-PAST
'My friend saw your dog.'

Let's practice! *How would you say the following in Alabama?*

(39) a. My cat saw your dog.
b. Your cat saw my dog.

(40) a. My dad saw your corn.
b. Your dad saw my corn.

(41) a. My chicken saw your house.
b. Your chicken saw my house.

(42) a. My friend saw your language.
b. Your friend saw my language.

- If you are interested, at the end of this handout you can find how to talk about possession when the POSSESSOR is plural: the individual or thing described by the noun is owned by more than one person.
- We will go over that at another time, learning how to say that something is "our", "y'alls"', and "their".

Possessives I Easy Recipe

[**Possessor** + **Noun** + **Case**]

Possessor Morphemes:

	Singular	Plural	
1	**cha-** 'my'	**ko-/po-** 'our'	*1st person = speaker*
2	**chi-** 'your'	**hachi-** 'y'all's'	*2nd person = addresse*
3	**noun** (e.g. *Ava*)	**noun** (e.g. *children*)	*3rd person = someone else*

(43)
a. **cha-** + **holchifa** = *chaholchifa* 'my name'
b. **chi-** + **holchifa** = *chiholchifa* 'your friend'
c. **Ava** + **holchifa** = *Ava holchifa* 'Ava's name'
d. **ko-/po** + **holchifa** = *koholchifa* or *poholchifa* 'our friend'
e. **hachi-** + **holchifa** = *hachiholchifa* 'ya'll's friend'
f. **poskoha** + **holchifa** = *poskoha holchifa* 'children's friend'

Possessives II Easy Recipe

[**Possessor** + **Noun** + **Case**]

Possessor Morphemes:

	Singular	Plural	
1	**am-** 'my'	**kom-/pom-** 'our'	*1st person = speaker*
2	**chim-** 'your'	**hachim-** 'y'all's'	*2nd person = addresse*
3	**noun** (e.g. *Ava*) **im-**	**noun** (e.g. *children*) **im-**	*3rd person = someone else*

(44)
a. **am-** + **okla** = *amokla* 'my friend'
b. **chim-** + **okla** = *chimokla* 'your friend'
c. **Ava im-** + **okla** = *Ava imokla* 'Ava's friend'
d. **kom-/pom** + **okla** = *komokla* or *pomokla* 'our friend'
e. **hachim-** + **okla** = *hachimokla* 'ya'll's friend'
f. **poskoha im-** + **okla** = *poskoha imokla* 'children's friend'